

CHAPTER FIVE

5. THE STAFFING FUNCTION

5.1. Staffing: Overview

Management teams on successful firms excel at many human resource management skills. **Staffing (including recruiting, selecting, hiring and training of employees)** is among the skills that become more important as the complexity and overall level of performance of a firm business increases. With increasing size and improving performance comes people complexity: more things accomplished through employees, more delegation to key employees and more reliance on employees to maintain a routine that assures superiority. Any cynical attitudes managers have about employees need to be replaced with positive attitudes.

The organizing function of management defines each position or category of positions. Staffing follows with the filling and keeping filled all positions. Recruiting a pool of applicants for a position, selecting new employees from among the pool of applicants, training new employees and retraining experienced employees are the key elements of the staffing function. Managing resignations and discharges is also part of staffing. Staffing may be mistakenly limited to regular employees. Generally:

- It is the process of setting the right person to the right place at work.
- Staffing is the proper and effective planning of manpower requirement and development of personnel to perform the duties and responsibilities specified by the organization.

5.2. Major Principles or Guides of Staffing

Even though there are no universally accepted staffing principles, the following are useful as guidelines for understanding the staffing function:

- a. **The Principle of Job Definition:** The more precisely the results expected of managers are identified, the more the dimensions of their position can be defined.
- b. **The Principle of Managerial Appraisal:** The more clearly verifiable objectives and required managerial activities are identified, the more precise can be the appraisal of managers against these criteria.

This principle suggests that performance should be measured both against verifiable objectives as in an appraisal approach based on managerial activities within the functions of planning, organizing, staffing, leading, and controlling are carried out.

- c. **The Principle of Open Competition:** The more an enterprise is committed to the assurance of quality management, the more it will encourage open competition among all candidates for management positions.

Violation of this principle has led many firms to appoint managers with inadequate abilities. Although social pressures strongly favor promotion from within the firm, these forces should be resisted whenever better candidates can be brought in from outside. At the same time, the application of this principle obligates an organization to appraise its people accurately and to provide them with opportunities for development.

- d. **The principle of Management Training and Development:** The more management training and development are integrated with the management process and enterprise objectives, the more effective the development programs and activities will be.

This principle suggests that, in the system approach, training and development efforts are related to the managerial functions, the enterprise, and the professional needs of managers.

e. The Principle of Training Objectives: The more precisely the training objectives are stated, the more likely are the chances of achieving them.

The analysis of training needs is the basis for training objectives that give direction to development and facilitate the measurement of the effectiveness of training effort. This principle brings into focus the contribution that training makes to the purpose of the enterprise and the development of individuals.

f. The Principle of Continuing Development: The more an enterprise is committed to managerial excellence, the more it requires managers to practice continuing self-development. This principle suggests that in a fast-changing and competitive environment, managers must get cannot managerial knowledge continuously, reevaluate the managing, and improve their managerial skills and performance to achieve enterprise results.

5.3. Activates of the Staffing Function

5.3.1. The Human Resource or Personnel Department

The staffing function involves three separate but interrelated activates. Human resource management as a function, is an activity that is handled by a staff official whose primary duty is assisting and advising line managers. The ultimate authority for making staffing and other human resources decisions rests with the line managers who rely upon the expertise of the personnel department to provide major assistance in recruiting, testing, conducting screening interviews, training, facilitating the performance appraisal process, and proposing solution to grievances and disciplinary problems (Kurtz, pp. 245-246).

5.3.2. Human Resource Planning/Manpower Planning

Manpower planning is the development of a comprehensive staffing strategy for meeting the future human resource needs of an organization. It is the process of determining how an organization by getting the right number of qualified people into the right job at the right time (Rue and Byars, 1002, p. 294) should move from its current manpower position to its desired position. The manager strives to have the right number and the right kinds of people at the right time and place according to the plan.

Human resource planning consists of the following activities.

- i. Forecasting future manpower requirement. This is done in terms of mathematical projection in by comparing projected demand and projected supply.
- ii. Assessing current needs by making an inventory of present manpower. Job analysis is carried out and job descriptions are also examined. Job analysis is the process of determining the fundamental elements of jobs through systematic observation and analysis by a team of trained specialists. Job description is a clear and concise summary of the duties of a specific job and the qualification for holding it. Job descriptions are useful staffing tools for achieving productive individuals that fit the organization.

- iii. Anticipating manpower problem by projecting present resources into future and comparing them with the forecast of requirements to determine their adequacy, both quantitatively and qualitatively.
- iv. Planning the necessary programs of recruitment, selecting, training, development, utilization, transfer, promotion, motivation and compensation to ensure that future manpower requirements are properly met.

Human resource planning leads to the maximum utilization of human resources, reduces excessive labor turnover and high absenteeism; improves productivity and helps in achieving the objectives of an organization.

Human resources planning is important for an individual because it helps him to improve his skills and utilize his capabilities and potential to the utmost. It is important for an organization because it improves its efficiency and productivity. It is only through initial manpower planning that capable hands are made available for promotion in the future.

5.3.3. Recruitment and Selection

Recruitment is a process of getting potential employees willing to apply for a job or jobs in an organization. Its aim is to develop and maintain adequate manpower resources upon which an organization can depend when it needs additional employees. (K.K. Ahuja, 1998:43)

- i. **Sources of Manpower:** In general, there are two sources from which employees can be recruited
 - a) **Internal sources:** Personnel already on the pay roll of an organization (present force) when a vacancy occurs, somebody from the existing force can be upgraded, transferred, promoted or sometimes demoted.
Personnel that were once on the payroll, such as those on leave of absence, those who quit voluntarily or those on production lay-off can be used as internal sources.
 - b) **External sources**
 - ✓ New entrants to the labor force
 - ✓ The unemployed
 - ✓ Retired experienced persons
 - ✓ Others in the labor force such as married women.
- ii. **Methods of Recruitment**
 - a) Direct methods. Recruiting from educational and professional institution
 - b) Indirect methods. Advertising in newspapers, on the radio, in trade and professional journals.
 - c) Third-party methods-using commercial or private employment agencies, state agencies placement of schools, colleges, and professional associations, friends, relatives, etc.
- iii. **Selection Procedures:** The completeness of the procedure depends upon the following factors:
 - a) The nature of selection;
 - b) The length of the probationary or trial period. The longer the period, the greater the uncertainty in the mind of the selected candidate about his future.
- iv. **Steps in Selection Procedure:**
 - a) Reception and preliminary screening from application.

- b) Application-blank-a fact finder which helps one in learning about an applicant's background and life history.
- c) A well conducted interview to explore the facts and get at the attitudes of the applicant and his familiarity to the job and the company.
- d) A physiological testing to explore the surface area and get an objective look at a candidate suitability for a job.
- e) A reference check (by mail, telephone, in person)

5.3.4. Staff Utilization:

Staff utilization is the placing of a new employee on a position with a defined responsibility to get him/ her do the job. To be considered useful, an individual has to contribute his/ her share to the achievement of the objectives of the organization.

- a) **Placement and Induction.** Placement is enabling an employee to take his/ her position. This is followed by an orientation program which is known as induction. The employee is made to learn about the organization in order to adjust himself/ herself without difficulty.
- b) **Promotion:** Covers a change of position which calls for greater responsibilities, and usually involves higher pay, better terms and conditions of service, and therefore, a higher status.
- c) **Demotion:** Demotion is a staff utilization activity that is more of a punitive measure. An employee who is demoted is lowered down of his/ her status, salary and responsibility when serious breaches of duty are found and proved
- d) **Transfer:** is a horizontal or lateral movement of an employee from one job, section department, shift, plant or position to another place where salary, status, and responsibility are the same. It is not promotion or demotion or a change in job status other than movement from one job to another.

5.3.5. Staff or Personnel or Manpower Training and Development.

a) Definition of Training, Development, and Education:

Training is a process of learning a sequence of programmed behavior. It is an application of knowledge which gives people an awareness of the rules and procedures to guide their behavior. It aims at improving the performance of employees on their current job or preparing them for an intended job. The imparting of information (knowledge) or skill could be done through instruction or drill (Page are, 1981:369).

Many people find it very difficult to differentiate between training, development and education. Of course, precise definitions are not possible; even if tried, the result would be misleading. But for the present purpose the following would suffice.

Development is a related process that covers not only those activities which improve job performance, but also those that bring about growth of the personality of the individual that undergoes the development program. Development aims at helping individuals to progress towards maturity and realization of their potential capacities so that they become not only good employees, but better men and women.

Education, on the other hand, is the understanding and interpretation of knowledge. Education develops a logical and rational mind that can determine relationships among

pertinent variables and thereby understand situations and phenomena. It involves skills and expertise which can be provided by educational institutions (C.B. Memorial, 1998:307-308).

b) The Need for Training: Training is necessary because of the following reasons.

- Trained personnel are not available. To fill the gap, employees must be trained.
- Since one of the inherent needs of enterprises is surplus production, increasing productivity would be possible if training is given.
- Proficiency in latest methods and techniques of production would bring about higher output of quality goods and better use of resources.
- Trained personnel would develop job satisfaction and this can improve organizational climate.
- Through training the health and safety of employees can be improved, because the development of skills would result in dexterity and reduced accidents.
- Training enables personnel gain individual growth and prevent manpower obsolescence (page are, 1981; C.B. Mamoria, 1998:309-310).

c) Types of Training Methods or Techniques: employees can be trained through different types of training programs, methods or techniques. The following are some of the personnel training programs/methods/ techniques.

- i. **On-the-Job-Training:** This training is conducted systematically while the employee working in the organization. The employee learns skills, abilities, facts and develops attitudes which enable him/her to advance organizational and personal goals.
When the job to be learned is relatively simple, and special classes or instructors are unnecessary, the immediate supervisor or another experienced worker can handle the training. This makes it very simple and economical.
- ii. **Off-the-Job Training:** This is any form of training conducted away from the individual's work area. This approach is utilized in instances in which the participation of the new worker would slow production and/or be potentially dangerous.

In such instances the organization can construct a training area equipped with similar machines and processes as those found on the job. This approach, called vestibule training, is designed to build skills by allowing the individual to perform the work under the supervision of a trainer before being assigned to the actual work area.

It is also typically used when the employee must gain a considerable body of knowledge and theory before beginning the job. Classroom training programs utilize traditional techniques of lectures, programmed instruction materials, seminars, case studies or learning by doing, role playing, conferences, films, and other audio-visual aids, as well as special machines to develop the necessary skills before the individual is assigned to the work area (C.B. Mamoria, 1998: 336-342).

5.3.6. Separations:

Definition: Separation means stop giving service in an organization; this usually takes place as a result of the following.

Types or Features of Separation:

- **Resignation:** on grounds of health, physical disability, better opportunities elsewhere, or maladjustment with company policy and officers, or other personal reasons; sometimes an

employee may be asked to submit his resignation before his being charged for serious matters.

- **Discharge:** separation of an employee from the pay-roll for violation of company rules or for inadequate performance
- **Suspension:** a serious punishment during which an employee receive a subsistence allowance while an enquiry goes on because of discipline case.
- **Retrenchment:** a permanent termination of services of employee for economic reasons. Part of the work force can be found to be superfluous.
- **Lay-offs:** and indefinite separation of an employee from the pay-roll due to his/her surplus skills. This is done to reduce the financial burden of an organization when human resources cannot be utilized profitably.

5.3.7 Labor Turnover:

It's the rate of change in the working staff of an organization during a definite period. It is the shifting of the work force into and out of an organization, i.e., old employees leave and new ones enter into service in a given period. It is defined as a measurement of inarticulate labor unrest.

5.3.8. Legal Aspects of Human Resource Management

Personnel management as an important part of the overall management cannot be independent of the laws of the country in which it is practiced. There are relevant laws which affect both public and private employees in every country. These laws are known as labor laws.

Labor laws are the product of the particular conditions and circumstance of each country. They take into consideration the history, traditions economic and social structure and political orientation. Their common objective has been to ensure a steady growth in the minimum standards of working, employment and living conditions for workers (K.K. Ahuja, 1998:859). Labor laws define the legal rights and obligations of employers and employees. They also provide guidelines for their day-to-day relationships. Labor laws can be categorized as follows:

- Laws regulating working conditions
- Laws regulating industrial relations
- Laws regulating wages and bonus
- Laws regulating social security measures covering maternity, sickness, occupational disease, payment of gratuity, provident fund and family pension.
- Laws regulating training covering apprentices act, employment exchanges, compulsory notification of vacancies act.
- Laws regulating welfare and living conditions (K.K. Ahuja, 1998: 859).

Authorities in the field of personnel management hold the view that workers must be acquainted with the various laws listed above. Awareness minimizes the conflict between the management and workers in an organization. Management knows what the benefits, facilities and other amenities are expected to be provided according to these laws. If the workers are also aware of labor laws, management can not deviate from those statutory requirements, rather they will be forced to implement them. If workers are aware of provisions of various labor laws, they can bargain more effectively (K.K. Ahuja, 1998, 859).

5.3.9. Performance Appraisal or Periodic Evaluation

Part three of the Ethiopian Civil Servants Proclamation deals with staffing and performance evaluation. There are several basic required tools for retaining, training or developing, penalizing and finally discharging employees. One of these tools is the performance appraisal or periodic evaluation.

Planning human resource requirements is one of the essential activities within the staffing function of management. As a process, management does not stop at the planning function. It culminates in the controlling aspect, which cannot exist unless objectives and goals are set in the planning function.

Whether or not an organization has achieved its set objectives and goals, is tested through appraisal or evaluation. One of the areas that is appraised is the human or employee effectiveness and efficiency without which productivity is unthinkable. Performance appraisal or evaluation is the rating of effectiveness, efficiency and productivity of an employee on the basis of his/her job description and the ethical norms that the organization has adopted and does expect its employees to stick to. The evaluation is done regularly and periodically by the employee's immediate superior.

Employees can be evaluated in different ways:

- i. Informal systems of evaluation: Informal systems of evaluation too often result in supervisors emphasizing personal traits such as appearance, sincerity, and loyalty rather than such factors as quantity of work and the quality of the work. In cases where there is no formally organized system, supervisors may not be consistent in evaluating all workers in a department.
- ii. Formal systems of performance appraisal bring order to the appraisal process and thereby reduce worker complaints about favoritism, inequity, and lack of fairness. To avoid these it is attempted to evaluate all employees consistently on fair criteria. Fairness is important since performance appraisals are often significant factors in determining pay increases and promotion opportunities.

To achieve equal treatment, a number of appraisal formats such as the ones described below exist.

- a. Graphic rating scales are performance appraisal forms listing a number of factors, with a continuum for each factor ranging from poor or unacceptable to superior. The rater checks the appropriate degree of merit on each factor being evaluated. Since each degree of merit typically has been assigned a point value, total scores can be determined for the purpose of allocating merit pay increases or other rewards.
- b. Forced distribution scales require evaluators to place a predetermined percentage of persons being evaluated into four or five categories. The advantage of this format over the graphic rating scale is that it forces the rater to differentiate among subordinates by prohibiting the common characteristic of categorizing persons as an average or above average.
- c. Management by objective (MBO) involves by both superior and subordinate on the subordinate's objectives for the forthcoming period. At the end of the period, the subordinate is evaluated on how well he/she performed in meeting the agreed-upon objectives.

It is common practice for supervisors to discuss the formal appraisal results with the subordinate during an appraisal interview. Such an interview provides an opportunity for both the evaluator and the subordinate to discuss differences of opinions concerning performance and the causes of and possible solutions for unsatisfactory performance.

The format below can be useful in an open organization which allow the participation of employees in performance appraisal.

GENERAL APPRAISAL OF EMPLOYEE PERFORMANCE

No	Complete items 1 through 8 for all employees and items 9 and 10 when applicable. Differences between ratings by employee and by supervisor must be discussed	To be completed by employee			To be completed by supervisor			
		Exceeds Expectations	Meets Expectations	Need Improvements	Exceeds Expectations	Meets Expectations	Need Improvements	Insufficiency opportunity to observe
1	Job Knowledge: consider overall knowledge of duties and responsibilities as required for current job or position							
2	Productivity: Evaluate amount of work generated and completed successfully as compared to amount of work expected for this job/position.							
3	Quality : Rate correctness, completeness, accuracy and economy of work overall quality							
4	Initiative: Self-motivation-consider amount of direction required; seek improved methods and techniques; consistence in trying to do better.							
5	Use of Time: uses available time wisely; is punctual accomplishes required work on or ahead of schedule.							
6	Planning: Sets realistic objectives; establishes logical priorities							
7	Follow-up: Maintains control of workloads; allocates resources economically; insures that assignments are completed accurately							
8	Human Relations: Establishes and maintains cardinal work climate; promotes harmony and enthusiasm; displays sincere interest in assisting other employees							
9	Leadership: Sets high standards; provides good managerial example; encourages subordinates to perform efficiently; communicates effectively.							
10	Subordinate Development: Helps subordinates plan career development;							

	grooms potential replacements; gives guidance and counseling							
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5.4. Recruitment and Selection of Employees

Following some proven guidelines increase the chances of finding and keeping desirable employees. However, no process can guarantee selection success. Even if the seemingly "right" person was hired six months, a year or three years ago, now it may seem that the "wrong" person was hired. The following eight-step process increases the chances of hiring success:

- i. Determine the business' labor and management needs
- ii. Develop a current job description
- iii. Build a pool of applicants
- iv. Review applications and select those to be interviewed
- v. Interview
- vi. Check references
- vii. Make a selection
- viii. Hire

Step 1: Determine the Business' Labor and Management Needs

The labor and management needs of the business should guide its hiring decisions. An understanding of the goals for the farm business and its current and long run constraints to progress helps identify desirable employee characteristics. Goals and performance standards should be specifically addressed before the search for a new employee begins. This helps identify those specific things expected to be accomplished through hired farm workers in general and new employees in particular.

Step 2: Develop a Current Job Description

Job descriptions help both the employer and employees by answering three questions: What does the jobholder do? How is it done? Under what conditions is it done? The job description has at least four parts:

- i. Job title,
- ii. A brief one or two sentence summary of the job,
- iii. A detailed listing of the major tasks involved in the job summarized under three to seven general headings, and
- iv. A listing of the knowledge, skills and abilities necessary to do the job.

Job descriptions are typically one page long. The brevity requires a terse, direct writing style. Simple words with single meanings should be used. Action verbs in the present tense should be used in defining the job duties, e.g., milks twice per day five days per week, completes a performance evaluation at least annually for each employee supervised. The specifics of the job should be clear from the job description. The job title, job summary and description of duties should be completely consistent.

Step 3: Build a Pool of Applicants

Although there are many methods of getting job applicants, word of mouth and help wanted ads are likely to generate the most applicants. Word of mouth involves current employees, neighbors, agribusiness contacts, veterinarians and others who come in contact with potential employees. Word of mouth is fast and low cost. However, it limits the scope of the job search

because qualified applicants may not hear about the position. Current employees enthusiastic about their jobs can become highly effective recruiters.

Following a seven-step process should result in an effective want

- i. Lead with a positive statement or job characteristic that attracts attention give the job title
- ii. Say something positive about the farm describe the job
- iii. Explain qualifications necessary for success in the position
- iv. Provide information on wages and benefits, as appropriate
- v. Indicate how to apply for the job

Step 4: Review Applications and Select those to be Interviewed

Some applicants will be excluded from further consideration based on the application form. A pre-interview can also be used to help identify applicants to be invited for a formal interview. Having interested people visit the farm to fill out an application form can provide opportunity for a few general questions about experience and interest in the job. Promising candidates can be given a mini-tour of the farm providing opportunity for general conversation about the dairy industry, livestock, farm work and machinery.

Step 5: Interview

Farm employers use applicant interviews more than any other selection tool in deciding whom to hire. Employers can lose outstanding applicants through poor interviewing. On the other hand, they can use excellent interviewing skills to help sell a job opportunity to applicants.

Use these questions to guide preparation for interviewing:

- i. Who will be on the interview team?
- ii. How will we divide time between the formal interview and informal discussion including a farm tour?
- iii. What questions will we ask in the interview?
- iv. How will we record our evaluations of each interviewee?
- v. Where will we conduct the interview?

Interviewing is difficult. Knowing how to do it well makes it enjoyable. Some do's and don'ts can serve as reminders on how to improve your interviewing skills.

Do:

- Make sure the applicant does most of the talking.
- Make the interview fun for you and the applicant.
- Listen
- Be attentive.
- Concentrate on the interview and what the applicant is saying
- Show enthusiasm throughout the interview.
- "Read" nonverbal messages.

Don't:

- Project the answer you want from the applicant, e.g., "You do likes cows don't you."
- Cut an interview short because the first ten minutes didn't go well.
- Let your note taking during the interview detract from the "flow" on the interview.
- Read questions to the applicant.

- Let your facial expressions and other nonverbal responses show your dissatisfaction with the applicant's answers.
- Add a series of follow up questions to explore "interesting" side issues.

Immediately after the interview and certainly before interviewing another candidate, you should complete an interview form and summarize your impressions of the applicant. Relying on memory to recall key points about applicants will lead to confusion among the applicants and vagueness about strengths and weaknesses.

Step 6: Check references

References can confirm information gathered through the application form and the interview. References can provide additional information about those applicants to whom you are still giving serious consideration. Some employers skip this step because of previous employers' reluctance to share any useful information out of fear of defamation litigation. Reference checks can still be productive. Personal visits or telephone conversations will be more productive than asking for written comments. Keep in mind that some references have reason to give less than candid information. Some employers may praise a problem employee in hope that an offer from another farm will solve a messy problem.

Step 7: Make a selection

The objective in making a selection is to be as objective as possible given the job description; knowledge, skills and abilities necessary to do the job; and the information available concerning each applicant. Selection biases can easily creep into the selection process

➤ Five potentially important selection biases are:

- Stereotyping:** Attributing certain characteristics to a particular group of people. "People Who grew up on dairy farms like animals?"
- Halo effect:** Regarding highly an individual who has characteristics you particularly like. "A person, like me, who drives a Ford, prefers Jerseys and is a Chicago Cubs fan will be a good employee."
- First impressions:** Judging prematurely based on appearance, handshake or voice. "He has a good firm handshake, a friendly smile, no ear rings, and short hair. I knew before the interview started that he would be a good employee."
- Contrast:** Measuring against the last person interviewed. "After that last person we interviewed, I had begun to think we would never find an acceptable person."
- Staleness:** Discounting individuals who were interviewed early in the process by giving preference to the individuals interviewed just before they make the selection.

Step 8: Hire a person

Make an oral offer in person or by telephone to your first choice followed by a written offer that summarizes the key conditions of employment. In making the offer, emphasize that the applicant is the first choice among several qualified people. Show enthusiasm and make obvious your hope that this person will soon be joining your farm team.

The written employment agreement can be a letter of explanation or a form with blanks filled in as appropriate. Whatever the form, the agreement should include a description of the job, a statement that the employment is "at will," compensation, benefits, work schedules and the other important details.

Other applicants interviewed will want to know the outcome of your job search. Every person interviewed should have a follow up message from you. A form letter should be sent to all applicants interviewed saying that the position has been filled and thanking them for their interest in the job. The follow up letter should have a positive tone rather than be a "I reject you" letter.

5.5. Career Planning and Career Path

Career planning is a systematic process by which an individual selects career goals and the path to these goals. From the organization's point of view, career planning means helping the employees to plan their career in terms of their capacities within the context of the organization's requirement.

Career planning involves formulating an organizational system of career movement and growth opportunities for employees from the time of their appointment in the organization to their retirement time. Individual employee who can fill planned future positions will be identified and prepared for taking up these positions.

➤ Steps in career planning

The career planning process generally involves the following steps:

- a. **Identifying individual needs and aspirations:** The first step involved in the career planning process is to take up an objective analysis of the hopes and aspirations of different categories of employees. It becomes necessary to identify and communicate the career goals, aspirations, paths and opportunities available to each employee because most of the employees are unaware about them.
- b. **Analyzing Career Opportunities:** The second step is to analyze the organizational setup, future plans and career system of the employees in order to identify the career opportunities available to them within the organization, and to determine the career paths for each job.
- c. **Identifying Match and Mismatch:** The third step is to identify and compare specific areas of match and mismatch for different categories of employees by developing a mechanism to compare and assimilate individual employee's aspirations and organizational career system.
- d. **Formulating and Implementing Career Strategies:** The fourth step in the career planning process is to formulate alternative strategies covering areas of change and adjustment and prepare and implement action plans including acquiring resources for achieving goals.
- e. **Periodic Review of Career Plans:** The final step in the career planning process is to undertake periodical review of the career development plans for the purpose of finding out whether the development plans are contributing to effective utilization of finding out of manpower by catching employee-objectives to job-needs.

“Fire right fire right”

